

[Return to Search](#)

An account of the Zande

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"Though most people do their crops at the same time of year, there is often a difference of a month or more between them...."

241
Tillage

The first operation in the preparation of the ground is the clearing away of the grass and bushes, and this takes a long time, for one cannot start at it early in the morning or he would be wetted by the dew falling from the tall grass on to his back, and so there is not time to do very much before the sun is too hot to go on, while a suggestion to return to work in the afternoon was looked on as a capital joke. When it is at last accomplished, the small trees that have been left standing are cut down at the height of the hip, and the larger ones ringed and killed by a fire lit round the base. The hoed grass when dry is burnt, and the branches and sticks not consumed are dragged to the edges of the field or made into heaps, and eventually feed the family fire. Some people, for certain crops, do not burn the grass, but sow the seed through it, and it does very well. An energetic man will sometimes make a fence of branches round his field to keep out waterbuck and buffalo, but this is uncommon and not very efficacious...."

241
Tillage

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